

The Walkthrough

This is where the contract is won or lost. Everything before it exists to produce one.

Two jobs, in this order: gather enough to price the job profitably, and become the person they want to hire. Most operators do the first and forget the second — then compete on price, because they gave the buyer nothing else to compare.

Before you go — ten minutes

- Re-read your notes. Know what they said prompted this.
- Know the trigger and its date. Mention it once, naturally.
- Confirm the appointment that morning. No-shows are a scheduling failure, not bad luck.
- Bring: a measuring wheel or laser, your phone, this checklist, your insurance certificate, two cards.
- Know your walk-away number. Decide it now, not in the room.

Arrive five minutes early and look at the building the way a visitor does. The entrance glass, the lobby, the parking area. That's the impression their clients form, and it's often the thing they most want fixed.

Discovery — the eight things to establish

If you haven't already, get these before or during the visit.

#	What	Ask
1	Square footage	<i>"Roughly how big is the space?"</i>
2	Frequency	<i>"How often does it need cleaning?"</i>
3	Current situation	<i>"How's it handled today?"</i>
4	What prompted this	<i>"What made you open this up?"</i>
5	Who decides	<i>"Besides yourself, who'd be involved?"</i>
6	Timing	<i>"When would you want someone starting?"</i>
7	Budget frame	<i>"Do you have a figure in mind, or should I put a proposal together?"</i>
8	Anything unusual	<i>"Anything about the space I should know?"</i>

Question 4 changes the proposal. If the answer is "the last crew kept missing the restrooms," you lead with quality control. If it's "we just moved in," you lead with a clean start and a transition plan. Same building, different proposal.

Question 5 is where deals die quietly. An office manager who can't sign, in a conversation you thought was with the decision maker, costs you a walkthrough.

Measure and record

Numbers first. Memory is not a measurement.

Capture	Detail
Cleanable square footage	Not gross leased. Exclude what you won't clean.
Floor types	Carpet, hard floor, tile, specialty. Each cleans at a different rate.
Restrooms	Count, fixtures, traffic level
Kitchen / breakroom	Count, and whether dishes and appliances are in scope
Glass	Interior, entry doors, partitions
Trash	Desk-side count, central collection, dumpster location and distance
Occupancy	Headcount and pattern — the real driver of restroom and trash load
Access	Keys, codes, badges, alarm, after-hours procedure
Storage	Is there a closet, or does everything travel in the van?
Equipment	What stays, what you supply

Photograph everything. Time-stamped photos document pre-existing damage and make your proposal specific in a way your competitors' won't be.

The five things that quietly destroy margin

Ask about every one. Each is a common reason a job that priced fine lost money.

1. **After-hours access.** A security desk that closes at 7pm turns a 9pm clean into an overtime problem.
2. **Elevator access.** No service elevator, or one that needs booking, adds real time every visit.
3. **Dumpster distance.** A shared dumpster 200 yards away behind a locked gate is not the same job as one at the back door.
4. **Day-porter expectations nobody mentioned.** "Occasionally someone spills something in the lobby" means an unplanned daytime visit.
5. **Floor care assumed into the monthly.** Strip-and-wax or carpet extraction quietly expected to be included. Establish now whether it's in scope or billed separately.

While you walk — become the vendor

They're deciding whether they trust you, and they're deciding it here.

Point out one thing nobody else will mention. Not a criticism — an observation:

"The entry glass takes the worst of the traffic here. If we're nightly, I'd put that on a twice-weekly detail rather than the standard wipe. It's the first thing your clients see."

Ask what's gone wrong before. "What's the thing that would make you call me?" The answer is the most useful sentence in the whole sale, and it goes straight into your proposal.

Never criticise the incumbent. It reads as sales talk, and they may have hired them. Talk about what you'd do.

Say what you can't do. If they want floor restoration and you subcontract it, say so on site. Finding out after a signature costs the relationship.

Before you leave

Three sentences, every time:

"I'll have a written proposal to you by Thursday. It'll have three options so you can see the trade-offs. If anything's unclear, call me — my mobile's on the card."

Then two questions:

1. "Are you getting other quotes?" — expect yes. It tells you what you're next to.
2. "What's your timeline for deciding?" — sets your follow-up honestly.

Get the proposal out within 48 hours. Competitors are bidding the same week, and whoever sends while the walk is fresh has a real advantage.

Pricing — two methods, and one of them governs

Price it both ways. **If they disagree by more than about 20%, one of your inputs is wrong.** Find out which before you send anything.

Method A — build it up from labour

```

production rate (sq ft per hour, by surface and density)
  → hours per visit
  → × visits per month
  → × fully loaded labour cost (wage + taxes + insurance + comp)
  → + supplies + equipment + travel
  → + overhead
  → + margin
  = monthly price

```

Method B — per square foot, as a sanity check

Compare your Method A figure against what similar jobs go for in your market.

Method A governs. Method B only tells you whether the market will accept what A produced.

Pricing off per-square-foot alone is the most common way operators win contracts they lose money on. A published rate range knows nothing about your drive time, your access constraints or your wage rates. Use your own numbers from jobs you've actually run.

Before you send

- Does it clear your walk-away number?
- Have you priced floor care separately, or deliberately included it?
- Is the first month different because of an initial deep clean? Say so.
- What happens if their headcount grows 30%? Put a review trigger in the terms.

No-bid is a legitimate outcome

Walk away, politely and in writing, when the scope needs capability you don't have, access makes the schedule impossible, the budget is below your floor, the site raises safety concerns, or the buyer was evasive.

"Having seen the space, I don't think we're the right fit — the floor restoration needs a specialist crew. I'd rather tell you now than under-deliver. Happy to recommend someone."

Record your no-bids. A pattern of them in one segment is telling you something about your targeting, and you'll never see it if you only log the jobs you bid.